Garlic Paste

No blender — muddler or knife

INGREDIENTS

- 8 garlic cloves, peeled
- 1/2 tsp coarse kosher salt
- 2 tsp olive oil (optional, for storage)

METHOD

1. Trim the tough root end off each clove. If a clove has a green sprout running through it, halve it lengthwise and pull the sprout out — bitter, and it won't break down.
2. Chop the cloves into rough lentil-sized pieces. Precision doesn't matter; smaller pieces just can't dodge the muddler.
3. Scatter the salt over the garlic. The coarse crystals are the abrasive doing the work — fine salt dissolves and grinds nothing.
4. Tip it all into a narrow, heavy bowl (better than wide and shallow — the garlic stays under the muddler). Press and twist against the bottom and lower sides, scraping the sides down every 30 seconds, until it's sticky and mostly smooth.
5. If the bowl fights you, move to a cutting board. Hold the chef's knife nearly flat and drag it across the pile at an angle, pressing as you go. Re-gather, chop through once, smear again. Repeat until smooth.
6. Use immediately, or stir in the olive oil until the paste is coated, jar it, and refrigerate.

NOTES

Yield: about 3 tablespoons.

Timing: sharpest in the first hour, mellows after that.

Storage: refrigerate and use within about 4 days, or freeze in a small ice cube tray. Never leave oil-covered garlic at room temperature.

The salt counts. It's part of the recipe, not a seasoning — subtract it from whatever dish this goes into.

Why paste at all: for high-heat roasting (hasselback potatoes, anything basted and returned to the oven) paste coats evenly instead of leaving exposed minced bits to scorch. For a quantity this small, a microplane straight into the butter or oil is faster than either method here.

From Jacob's notes. Method rewritten and condensed for personal kitchen use.